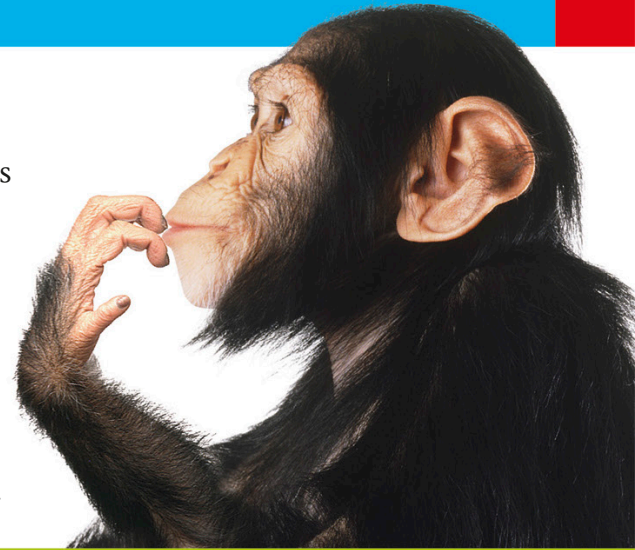




There is one species that has *taken over the whole planet*—*humans*. From *pole to pole*, humans have found a way to live and survive in every environment. This has put us in direct competition with every other organism for food, space, and other natural resources.

APE MAN

Humans are primates and, more specifically, members of a group of animals called hominids, or great apes. This group includes chimpanzees, orangutans, and gorillas. Our closest relatives are chimpanzees, who share 98.7 percent of our DNA. Scientists think our last common ancestor lived about 7 million years ago. Since then, there have been many species of humans but we, *Homo sapiens*, are the only one left.



Fitter and faster

Humans are also capable of making themselves physically better than average. Think of athletes competing in the Olympics. They train hard so that they can run, jump, and swim faster than ordinary humans. No other animal does that, because if they spent their time training they might not be able to escape from unexpected predators or run after their food at a moment's notice. Other animals only have to be fit enough to survive in the wild, and they don't waste their energy unnecessarily.



It's good to talk

Other animals make calls that indicate certain things, such as alarm, warning, or location. Humans, too, began to communicate with grunts and hand signals. Later, single words were joined together into sentences so that ideas could be expressed. By rearranging individual words humans can create endless new messages. Scientists have found that birds and dolphins have regional accents. There is even evidence that members of a dolphin pod give each other names so that they can talk directly to one another.

Hello there,
where have
you come from?
You're not a
member of
my pod!

What was that?
I don't understand
your accent!

